

Egypt

Alcohol, in the form of beer, was a critical component of Egyptian culture, as well. The Egyptian pyramids were constructed as funerary homes for the pharaohs (kings) of Egypt during the Old Kingdom (c. 2700–2200 BCE). The labor needed to build them was the primary form of tax payment provided by most Egyptians. After the harvest, work teams took turns providing a month or so of labor for the pyramids or other public works. While working, these laborers were housed with their work teams in bunkhouse-like barracks, complete with large, attached kitchens, and provided with food and drink: beer!

Watch the episode of the Discovery Channel show *Brew Masters* assigned for this module. Information about how to purchase the episode is available in the Syllabus under "Materials." The show is centered on the business Dogfish Head Craft Brewery, now owned by Boston Beer Company—the parent company of Sam Adams and the largest craft brewer in the U.S.—and the founder of Dogfish Head, Sam Calagione. Dogfish Head was one of the first breweries to create "ancient ales"—beers based on archaeological study of ancient alcohol. In the episode assigned here, you will learn about two of their ancient brews (Chateau Jiahu, an ancient Chinese rice beer, and Ta Henket, an Egyptian emmer beer) and meet Dr. Pat McGovern, an archaeochemist at the University of Pennsylvania who has devoted his career to the study of ancient alcohols (and discovered the earliest evidence of wine production (<https://www.pnas.org/doi/10.1073/pnas.1714728114>) ever found!).

As you watch the episode, think about these questions:

1. Why might it be important to use Egyptian yeast in the creation of an authentic ancient Egyptian beer?
2. What is the connection between bread and beer in Egypt? Why might the processes of creating both of these be depicted together in a tomb?
3. What are the limits of accuracy in recreating a recipe that was lost thousands of years ago? Is Ta Henket really an "ancient" recipe? What are the benefits and drawbacks of advertising it as such?